

Wordiness

Some writers think that the more words they use, the better an essay will sound. However, in academic writing in English, it is important to be as concise as possible. Unnecessary words and phrases do not improve your writing. Instead, they make it hard for readers to understand what you want to say.

The list on the left contains common **wordy** phrases. Good writers use the fewest words possible to make a point. In other words, they are being **concise**. Try to avoid using the phrases on the left; substitute them with the phrases on the right.

Wordy	Concise
at that point in time	at that time
despite the fact that + Subject + Verb	despite + Noun
for all intents and purposes	Ø—use nothing
for the purpose of	for
in my opinion, I believe...	in my opinion... or I believe...
in the event that	if
in the final analysis	finally
in the vicinity of	near
it goes without saying	Ø—use nothing
it seems unnecessary to point out	Ø—use nothing
made a statement saying	said
the reason why is	because
when all is said and done	Ø—use nothing

ACTIVITY 7 Wordiness

The introductory paragraph on the next page is from a cause-effect essay, and it contains seven examples of wordy phrases. Underline them as you find them. Then, on a separate piece of paper, rewrite the paragraph without the wordy phrases and make it more concise. Note: There is more than one correct way of rewriting this paragraph.

Fat-Free Food

In my opinion, I believe that the fat-free food industry is a tremendous money-making business. In fact, recent research has shown that fat-free products are considered only a minor prescription for the purpose of losing weight. Nutritionists have made statements saying that, for all intents and purposes, more important steps to losing weight are exercising and eating well-balanced meals. Despite the fact that this information has appeared, many people still seem to believe that, when all is said and done, eating fat-free food is the best dieting method. The content of the following essay shows some interesting reasons for this fat-free phenomenon.

Redundancy

Redundancy—a kind of wordiness—is the unnecessary repetition of information. When you write, you may want to impress your readers with an eloquent essay that is full of thought-provoking information. One way that writers often try to do this is by loading up on information. You may think, “The more information I have in my essay, the more my readers will enjoy it.” This is not usually the case, especially if, instead of adding information, you repeat what you have already said. Repetition can occur in the wording of short phrases as well as in sentences.

Redundant phrases. The list on the left contains commonly used redundant phrases. Try to avoid them in your writing. (If you are not sure why the phrases are redundant, look up the meanings of the two words.)

Change	To
collaborate together	collaborate
completely unanimous	unanimous
courthouse building	courthouse
descend downward	descend
erupt violently	erupt
exactly identical	identical
free gift	gift
loud explosion	explosion
merge together	merge
repeat again	repeat
unexpected surprise	surprise

Look at the example sentences below. The first sentence contains the same information as the second sentence.

Redundant Sentence The United States is the most influential power in the world. Partly because of its abundant material resources and stable political system, this country has great influence in global affairs.

Concise Sentence The United States has a great influence in global affairs in part because of its abundant material resources and stable political system.

ACTIVITY 8 Don't Say It Twice

Underline the redundant information in this paragraph. Then compare your work with a partner's.

Paragraph 2

Extrasensory Perception

Many people love to watch science-fiction stories on TV or at the movies. TV shows and films, such as *Star Trek*, are popular not only because they creatively show how future life might be in 300 years, but also because they introduce us to characters from other worlds, planets, and galaxies. Perhaps one of the most popular kinds of characters in these futuristic programs is a person with ESP, or extrasensory perception. ESP is a sense that allows one person to read the mind of another without the exchange of words. These characters, who can read minds and know the innermost thoughts and secrets of other people, often use their gift in less than noble ways. One must remember, however, that these scenes take place in an untrue and fictitious situation. A more interesting concept is to think about what would really happen if ordinary, everyday people possessed ESP.



ACTIVITY 16 | Editing for errors

Paragraph 3 has five errors: article (1), word form (1), subject-verb agreement (2), and unclear pronoun reference (1). Find and correct them.

ESSAY 5.2 (CONT.)

3 People who take care of themselves enjoy psychological beneficial. For example, regular exercise produces endorphins, which are the body's natural way to lift one's mood. Better nutrition means that they are also better equipped to deal with the stress of day-to-day life. Because of the effects that their healthy choices has on their bodies, people with the healthy lifestyle generally feel better about themselves. Most importantly, people who takes care of themselves agree that they feel better about themselves because they have more self-**confidence**.

Paragraph 4 has seven errors: article (2), word form (1), subject-verb agreement (2), and verb form (2). Find and correct them.

ESSAY 5.2 (CONT.)



4 Taking proper care of one's health also leads to better social life. The confidence that a person gains from feeling healthy and in shape improve his or her social and business relationships. Because health-minded people engage in a variety of physical activities, they had increased their chances of meeting other people. For example, many people makes friends at the locally gym. Similarly, someone who goes to beach frequently to play volleyball greatly increases his or her chances of meeting people. Since people who **pursue** a healthy lifestyle were feeling better about themselves, they are more likely to have **satisfying** social lives.



ACTIVITY 24 | Combining sentences

Combine the ideas into one sentence. You may change the word forms, but do not change or omit any ideas. There may be more than one answer.

SET 1:

Many American adults are obese.
This raises their risk of heart disease.
It also raises the risk of diabetes.

SET 2:

A hundred and fifty whales got stranded on a beach.
The beach was in Australia.
Rescuers could not reach them.
The weather was very bad.
There were a large number of sharks.

SET 3:

There was a period of rain in Kenya.
The rain was heavy.
It exposed a big crack in the earth.
The crack measures 50 feet deep.
It measures 65 feet wide.

SET 4:

Languages die with their last speaker.
Every two weeks a language dies.
Fifty to ninety percent will disappear.
This will happen by the next century.

SET 5:

The meat substitute is tasty.

The meat substitute is made from soy.

The meat substitute is made from peas.

Some consumers may not taste the difference.

SET 6:

Coral reefs are in danger.

One reason is development.

In Jordan, some coral reefs were moved.

These coral reefs are doing well.

OUTLINE OF A FOCUS-ON-CONTRAST ESSAY

Intro:

- **Background Information** about A & B
- **Shift to the focus:** In order for a person to reach an informed position between the two, it is essential to have a comprehensive grasp of how they differ from each other.
- **Thesis:** *This essay is to point out the differences between A & B that are mainly concerned with.....*

Body 1 – Difference 1:

- *The most obvious aspect where A and B differ from each other is
While A....., B.....*
(Support with your **reasoning** and evidence from sources)

Body 2 – Difference 2:

- *Another striking feature that distinguishes between the two is
A.....In contrast, B.....*
(Support with your reasoning and evidence from sources)

(Body 3 – Difference 3:

- *Finally, A and B are inherently contrasting in.....
A....., and this does not apply to B which/who.....*
(Support with your reasoning and evidence from sources)

Conclusion:

- **Summary of the essay task:** *This essay has examined the most significant distinctive features between A and B*
- **Restatement of thesis statement:** *From the analysis above, it is obvious that these mostly involve.....*
- **Closing statement** (*A prediction, a recommendation, a call to action, a warning*)

ESSAY WITH CONTRAST AND PERSONAL OPINION

Intro:

- **Background about Topic**
- **Shift to the focus:** *This sparks an ongoing debate as to which is a better option*
- **Thesis statement:** *This essay aims to illustrate the differences between..... and before a personal standpoint in the debate is given.*

Body 1: Differences

- **Topic sentence:** *Initially, it can be seen that the differences between A and B are quite pronounced.*
- **DIFFERENCE 1: *One key distinctive feature between them lie in***
A.....In contrast, B.....
(Support with your reasoning and evidence from sources)
- **DIFFERENCE 2: *Furthermore, A and B are inherently contrasting in.....***
A....., and this does not apply to B which/who.....
(Support with your reasoning and evidence from sources)

Body 2: Opinion

- *In my opinion,proves to be the superior option out of the two because of the following reasons. For one thing,..... In addition,.....*

Conclusion:

- **Summary of main ideas:** *This essay has explained how A and B are dissimilar to each other in terms of*
- **Restating your opinion:** *From my perspective,.....*
- **Closing statement:** *(In the future, it is likely that.....)*

ESSAY WITH BOTH COMPARISON AND CONTRAST

Intro:

- **Background about Topic**
- **Shift to the focus:** *This sparks an ongoing debate as to which is a better option*
- **Thesis statement:** *Rather than giving a personal perspective on this issue, this essay aims to analyze the similarities and differences between..... and*

Body 1: Similarities

- **Topic sentence:** *It can be seen that A and B are similar in some ways.*
- **SIMILARITY 1:** *One of the most significant similarities is*
A, and this is also true to B which.....
(Support with your reasoning and evidence from sources)
- **SIMILARITY 2:** *Another aspect that they have in common is*
A.....The similar thing also happens to B in which.....
(Support with your reasoning and evidence from sources)

Body 2: Differences

- **Topic sentence:** *On the other hand, the differences between A and B are quite pronounced.*
- **DIFFERENCE 1:** *One key distinctive feature between them lie in*
A.....In contrast, B.....
(Support with your reasoning and evidence from sources)
- **DIFFERENCE 2:** *Furthermore, A and B are inherently contrasting in.....*
A....., yet this does not apply to B which/who.....
(Support with your reasoning and evidence from sources)

Conclusion:

- **Summary of the focus:** *This essay has explained how A and B are alike and dissimilar to each other.*
- **Summary of main ideas:** *To be specific, the similarities between them are ...Meanwhile,.....are their main distinctive features*
- **Closing statement:** *(In the future, it is likely that.....)*

